

The floating light burned brighter with Cyranis's confirmation.

"Alright then. All I require is your body."

"You know," Cyranis said dryly, "you've been very kind to me—but I see you more as a friend."

The orb did not respond. The silence lingered long enough to make Cyranis uneasy.

"My body?" He took an instinctive step back.

"Just for a moment." The light drifted closer, its movement almost playful.

"I promise I will return it to you once you are free."

"But why?" Cyranis continued retreating, circling as the spark followed. "There has to be another way you can help me."

"No," the voice replied—calm, measured. "Not quickly, at least. I could grant you a portion of my power, but acclimation would take time."

The light burned hotter. The warmth it had offered bled away with each word.

"You want to leave as soon as possible. The simplest solution is to give you everything now and regulate the output myself."

Cyranis's back met cold stone.

"I will use only what is necessary," the voice continued. "You will not be harmed."

The words felt rehearsed.

Cyranis scrunched his face. "I don't trust you." His usual wit failed him. "There has to be another way."

The light paused. Its glow softened, almost apologetic.

"You are right," it said. "We can proceed with care instead of urgency. But I cannot promise how long it will take—or whether you will escape at all."

Hope and despair warred in Cyranis's chest. His gaze dropped.

"And if I agree?"

The spark stopped moving.

"I promise your freedom."

Its light flared—cold and harsh, like the dungeon lamps overhead.

“And the Guard who put you here will be punished.”

The clamor of the other prisoners died instantly.

Cyranis looked up, rage igniting in his eyes.

“Really?”

“Really,” the Light echoed. “Your body will be returned when I am finished.”

*Finished.*

Did it want to help him—or did it just want his body?

Cyranis scratched his chin, then let his hand fall.

*Either way, it could get me out of here and the Guard would be destroyed.*

I can’t let it keep his body. Not for long. Somehow.

“Fine,” he muttered. “You give me my body back when you’re done with the Guard. And if this is a trick—then we’re done. Permanently.”

“Deal.”

The light surged forward and slammed into Cyranis’s chest.

The invisible mass knocked him off his feet, and onto his back. His eyes rolled white as his body convulsed against the stone. Bolts of wild energy burst from his skin, carving black scars into the floor of the cell.

Voices—too many, too loud—flooded his mind. Memories that were not his own burned behind his eyes.

Cyranis screamed. Thrashed.

Then went still.

He sat up.

His eyes rolled back into place, glowing gold. A twisted smile pulled itself wide across his face—then vanished, leaving nothing behind it.

The Laugafin rose to his feet. He closed his eyes, let his head fall back, and stretched as if waking from a long rest. Bone cracked as he flexed his fingers. He bounced once on his toes.

Golden eyes snapped sideways toward the neighboring cell.

The green-eyed stranger stumbled back from the bars, his limbs shaking as a smile tried—and failed—to hold its place.

“What are you?” The words scraped their way out of his throat.

The Laugafin’s mouth curved again, slow and deliberate.

“I’ll show you.”

He pressed his hands together. A bright light flared between his palms—blue, brilliant. The Laugafin clenched his fists, then raised them, stretching the light into a halo that hovered above his head.

The stranger’s eyes widened as understanding set in. Sweat welled along his skin.

“So the fish was an apostle,” he said. His smile wavered, but did not vanish. “And which god stands before me?”

“You may refer to me as Rhovan,” the Laugafin replied. “For now.”

“I’ve never heard of that god.” The stranger’s eyes narrowed. “What is your dominion?”

“That is not something you need concern yourself with.”

The stranger huffed and retreated into his cell. “Very well. Then do you intend to free everyone—or just yourself?”

The Laugafin approached the bars. “Only the body you see before you, unfortunately. But from what I can tell, the Laugafin is fond of you.” His golden eyes lingered a moment. “He may return for you. If you are lucky.”

Rhovan placed his hand against the bars. They did not resist him. Instead, his form flowed through the iron, slipping between the gaps like water down a drain.

The first step of his escape was completed.

Without joy or ceremony, he continued down the hall. Creatures shrank back into the shadows of their cages as he passed. After a short walk, the corridor opened into a wider chamber.

Two Skarnathi guards were inside.

One stood roughly twenty feet from the doorway, idly tracing patterns on his thigh as he watched the corridor. The other sat farther back at a scarred table, thirty feet away, a bottle resting loosely in his grip.

The two assessed the situation with no words exchanged, and moved to intercept at once.

The nearer guard advanced with purpose. The one at the table rose more slowly, setting down his drink as he stood.

Rhovan did not quicken his pace. He strolled forward, unconcerned, allowing the distance to close.

They met in the center of the room.

The first guard planted his feet and swung low, aiming for Rhovan's gut.

Rhovan did not block. Did not dodge.

The blow landed cleanly, lifting him off the stone and sending him airborne. The guard followed through without hesitation, driving a second strike forward—harder, higher—his fist crashing into the Laugafin's skull.

Rhovan's body ragdolled across the floor, skidding to a stop near the doorway he had just passed through.

The guards scoffed.

"I think this is the one Hamura captured a few months back," said the guard by the table.

"Looks like him," the other replied, rolling his shoulders. "More reckless than Hamura described."

"Do not harm him too much," the first guard said. "If he dies, his mark will be useless."

"I know." The second guard exhaled. "Whether he dies is up to him."

They laughed.

Then Rhovan laughed too.

The sound began as a wheeze—ragged, breathless—before swelling into something louder, richer. It echoed off the stone walls as his body twisted and pushed itself upright.

"It's been so long since I've felt this sensation!" he roared.

Blood streamed from his broken nose. He only grinned as he seized it and forced it back into place with a sharp crack. His fingers dragged across his face, lingering, before falling to his sides.

"So intense," he breathed, laughter still shaking his frame. "So real. How riveting."

His body quivered as the laughter faded at last.

“You’re lucky I’m in a hurry,” he said lightly. “Or I would have played with you.”

The amusement vanished.

A small frown crossed his face—brief, almost disappointed—before smoothing away into nothing. The air thickened. Fog crept outward, clinging low to the stone Rhovan’s eyes cut through the haze with a cold blue hue.

“So little time,” he said quietly. “I think I would have liked you both.”

With the energy in the room swelling, the guards moved more frantically. The one at the table drew a long sword from its sheath. The other slipped on brass knuckles and broke into a sprint.

Rhovan’s rhythm remained steady.

He raised his right hand, graceful and unhurried. The fog responded, creeping higher. The charging guard closed in fast. Rhovan turned his palm outward and locked eyes with his assailant. The guard was a breath away when Rhovan finished the act with a closing fist.

The fog rushed from the corners of the room and congealed around the guard’s head.

The guard barreled forward without control. Before he could crash into his target, Rhovan took a small step to the side—so effortless it almost seemed as though he hadn’t moved at all. The guard missed. Grabbing at his new confinement, he collided with the stone doorway. He folded, then hit the floor with another heavy thud, thrashing.

Gargled screams escaped the watery prison as he punched and clawed at the orb. To no avail.

Rhovan paused, briefly taking in his work. Emotionless eyes lingered on the helpless man before shifting to the next victim.

The remaining guard took a step back, weighing his options. He watched as a new pool of water formed in Rhovan’s palm. His choice was cemented with a tightening grip on his sword and a forward charge. He cried out as he crossed the room toward the Laugafin.

Rhovan thrust his hand toward him.

The water burst outward, slamming into the man’s face and clinging to it. The force ripped him off his feet, driving his head into the bedrock with a sickening crunch. He didn’t make it halfway.

Rhovan folded his arms behind his back and approached the fallen guard near the center of the room. The man was still alive, but his labored breathing and twitching limbs proved he was finished. Rhovan bent down and pressed his hand to the man’s chest, feeling the frantic hammer of his heart.

He paused.

Then, with a brief flash of blue in his eyes, an arc of water formed and sliced cleanly across the man's throat.

Rhovan touched the pooling blood, rubbing it between his fingers. A small smirk surfaced. Then a frown. Then nothing.

He flicked the blood from his hand, straightened, and continued deeper into the prison—never looking back.

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The sound of wet steps echoed through the halls as Rhovan entered a wide chamber. Behind him stretched hallway after hallway of scattered bodies and blood gone cold. Ahead floated a massive sphere, suspended lazily at the center of the room. Rows and columns of brands completely inscribed its surface. Between it and Rhovan lay a broad space cluttered with tables and dressers, opened toward the center like a crude arena.

Three Skarnathi stood within the room. Two of them, clad in clean leather attire, lingered near a secondary entrance at the back. They were not wealthy by any means, but they stood apart from the usual garb of the guards.

"I think we will take our leave now," one of them said, her voice firm. "You can deal with your men's mismanagement, I hope?"

"Of course." The third man bowed his head. "I will see to it at once. Please return to the capital safely."

"Mhm," she replied, already turning away. She and her partner stormed out together.

The remaining guard turned toward the Laugafin, the branded orb floating silently behind him. He was stocky, his arms mapped with burns and scars.

"I thought you had learned your lesson," the guard said, his voice low and strong. "But it is clear you require stricter teaching."

Rhovan rolled his eyes. "I have not been taught anything so far. Is it you who intends to change that?"

They advanced toward one another. The man's body was rigid, coiled with tension. Rhovan remained relaxed, his arms folded behind his back.

"You're the one I've heard about, right?" Rhovan prodded. Bloody footprints marked the floor in his wake. "Hamura?"

The man scoffed. "A lot more talkative this time."

“Your men spoke highly of you,” Rhovan said calmly. “They often cried out for your help at the end.”

Hamura clenched his jaw but said nothing. The room grew warmer—uncomfortably so. Reaching the opening at the center, they began to circle one another like sharks.

Rhovan smiled. “Fire magic? Then you are the one I’ve been looking for. Had you been the first I encountered, they might have lived.”

The circle tightened.

“This room sits at the heart of the encampment,” Hamura said. “If escape were your goal, you would never have passed through here. Even still, a weak being such as yourself should have fallen long before reaching this point.”

Rhovan stopped and gestured to the halo above his head.

Hamura spat on the stone. “No god would bless a fish.” He halted his circling and pressed his palms together. “A monster stands before me, and I will do my duty to return it to its cage.”

Rhovan stopped, his smile fading.

“Monster? No, no, no. What you see is a God. A patient one. As much as I’d love to make your death a quick one, your fate has already been sealed.”

Both fighters’ eyes flared with brilliant color. Mist churned behind Rhovan as steam rolled off Hamura’s frame. Sparks ignited around his wrists, forming twin rings of flame. The air popped and hissed as heat collided with moisture.

“I wish I could say I’m sorry,” Hamura said, his face hardening with resolve. “But a massacre like this will not go unpunished.”

“Your death will be painful,” Rhovan replied, unfolding his arms.

Rhovan reached out and closed his fist. Mist surged toward Hamura’s head, climbing the air and bursting against the ceiling in a cloud of steam. When it cleared, Hamura stood unmoved, hands raised beside his face.

Rhovan pressed on. His arm swept through the air like a composer’s baton. Sickles of water tore free behind him.

Hamura deflected the first, twisting its arc into hissing vapor. Then he moved—footwork tight, pivots sharp—dancing through the barrage as blades of water slashed into the bookcases behind him. When the assault ended, he spun back into his stance, breath labored, but smiling.

Blood seeped from Rhovan’s palm, the edges of the wound singed raw. He studied it for a moment.

“This body lasted quite long.”

He lifted his left hand and pointed to the floor. Water slithered up through cracks in the stone, cutting and twisting toward Hamura. He retreated, but it followed, matching every dodge. With a quick hop, he vaulted onto one of the tables.

A mistake.

Water erupted upward in jagged spires, splintering the wood and wrapping around Hamura’s legs. It yanked him back to the stone. His opponent immobilized, Rhovan drew his arm back like a thrown spear.

Hamura hinged at his knees, slamming his back against the stone as Rhovan thrust forward.

A needle-thin beam of water screamed past, carving a shallow line across Hamura’s forehead before boring a hole through the stone behind him. Moving fast, Hamura grabbed at his ankles as twin rings roared to life around them. Heat exploded outward. Steam swallowed the water whole.

Hamura twisted and sprang back to his feet.

Across the room, Rhovan’s arms were riddled with fresh wounds. Sores mottled his skin, his limbs trembling before dropping to his sides.

The two fighters paused—sweat and condensation dripping from their bodies as mist and heat hung heavy in the air.

“You are resilient,” Rhovan said as most of the mist began pooling at the center of the room. “I wish the Laugafin saw you more kindly. You would have been spared.”

“I wish you had stayed in your cage, Fish,” Hamura replied. His voice remained calm despite the insult. “No one needed to die for your futile escape.”

“Futile?” Rhovan echoed. “How injured this body is means nothing.”

His eyes churned as he retched, torrents of water spilling from his mouth. The fluid climbed his arms, shaping itself into long, whip-like tendrils.

“You will still die by these hands,” he continued, “even if they are broken.”

He sprang forward, arms trailing behind him. Hamura held his ground until the Laugafin entered his reach. His knee snapped upward to intercept.

Rhovan swept his arms down in a crossing arc to block. The guard held—but his lighter body was launched up and over Hamura’s shoulder.

Still airborne, Rhovan cracked one of the tendrils toward the back of Hamura's head. Hamura turned, halting the strike with a sharp chop.

Rhovan landed and immediately leapt back into the fray. The tendrils snapped through the air as he kept his spacing, hovering just at the edge of his own range and outside Hamura's.

Hamura retreated between the bookcases. The narrow aisles constrained the sweeping strikes of the Laugafin.

Rhovan adapted. He dipped a shoulder toward the floor and drove off it, launching into a spinning body slam. The tendrils whirled around him like the teeth of a saw.

The man pushed his magic to its limit. The rings around his wrists spun violently, scorching his skin.

The forces collided.

Hamura's boots grated against the stone as he held his guard. Scalding droplets peppered his face, cutting into his cheeks. With a deep roar, he redirected the killing blow into the bedrock.

Stone buckled beneath the impact—then stopped Rhovan's momentum cold.

Hamura did not hesitate.

Finally within reach, he seized the Laugafin's arms and transferred the flaming rings onto them, forcing the joints into unnatural angles. Bone split. Blood surfaced along Rhovan's upper arms.

Hamura reached down and hauled his battered foe up by the throat.

"You were saying?" he taunted.

Rhovan did not answer. Despite his injuries, his expression remained empty as he stared into Hamura's eyes, watching the red glow struggle to stay lit.

"Tired?" Rhovan asked.

Before Hamura could respond, he swung his broken arm upward. At the same moment, the condensed water surged into a spire.

Hamura blocked the flailing limb with his free hand—but the spire slammed into his shoulder. Slower than the beam, yet heavy enough to wrench the joint loose.

Hamura grimaced and staggered back. Rhovan pressed in, targeting the weakened side. A second beam followed, dropping straight toward Hamura's head.

He leapt aside, barely avoiding the killing blow.

Rhovan followed with sweeping slashes. Tendrils carved into Hamura's neck and flank, peeling flesh and drawing blood. Hamura slid back and clamped his palms together, forcing himself to begin the incantation.

Too slow.

A sharp crack split the air. Four fingers vanished in an instant. Two more lashes struck his ribs. Then his chest. Pain overwhelmed him, and he collapsed to one knee.

He looked up at Rhovan, eyes still fierce despite the loss. For the first time, the god's cold exterior broke—giving way to elation.

"Now *that* was fun!" Rhovan roared, flexing his ruined arms. "Your men were right to praise you, Hamura."

"Fun?" Hamura rasped between breaths. "Is that why you did this? For your own amusement?"

Rhovan closed the distance in an instant, stopping inches from his face. "Why do anything if not for enjoyment?" His eyes burned with passion.

"To help others? Because it is noble?"

He turned away with a sharp laugh.

"That devotion only lasts until they grow bored. Then they move on. You understand that, don't you?"

"No," Hamura said, forcing himself upright.

Rhovan snapped a tendril across his eye, dropping him again.

"What I did mattered," Hamura insisted through the pain. "This place matters more than me. My joy was always secondary to my duty. But a monster has no need for morels."

"Such wisdom," Rhovan said quietly, "is lost on creatures like you."

He buckled Hamura's knee with a twist of water.

"I speak from experience when I tell you this: nothing you have done will endure."

A final strike split Hamura's face, blood spilling freely.

"What you sacrificed to be a loyal pawn," Rhovan said, voice cold once more, "will be forgotten."

Rhovan unleashed a final frenzy of slashes. Flesh and sinew split beneath the assault until Hamura's ribs lay bare. When it was finished, the magic released its hold.

The orb of water above collapsed, raining down and washing the blood from Rhovan's skin. Clean once more, he turned away from what remained of his opponent.

Keys lay scattered among the debris. He gathered them without ceremony and left the room without another glance at the body.

The stirrings of the prisoners faded as his footsteps echoed deeper into the prison. One by one, voices fell silent.

Rhovan returned to the cell where it had begun—to the man waiting within.

"You returned?" the green-eyed prisoner whispered. He dropped to a knee, bowing his head. "Have you decided my fate?"

"I have," Rhovan replied. The Laugafin's voice faltered, strained and unfamiliar. "But I will not be the one you plead with."

The man looked up.

The golden light in the Laugafin's eyes darkened, swallowed by muddy brown. The blue halo above his head unraveled into nothing. The oppressive weight in the air lifted all at once.

Cyranis blinked.

His legs gave out. He collapsed to his knees, breath tearing from his chest as pain and memory rushed back into him at once.

The noise of the other prisoners fell away. All that remained was the sound of his ragged breathing—and blood trickling onto the stone.